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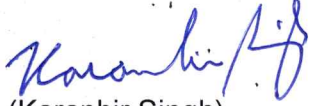
Circular to all Branches & Offices
Issued by Information Technology Department

Re: Password Policy (Version 1.0) of the Bank

Branches & Offices are hereby informed that the Password Policy (Version 1.0) of the Bank of the Bank has been approved by the Hon'ble Board of Directors through agenda item no.10 in its meeting no.01(01/2025) dated 07.05.2025. The policy will come into force with immediate effect & validity of the policy is for next three years from the date of approval. The approved Password Policy is attached here with this circular.

Kindly bring the content of this policy in the notice of all staff members of the Branches/Offices.

Yours faithfully,



(Karanbir Singh)
General Manager

Enclosure: As above

Password Policy: Security Standard & Guideline Document (Version 1.0)

Password Policy

Security Standard & Guideline Document

(Version – 1.0)

Uttar Pradesh Gramin Bank
Information Technology Department
Head Office, Lucknow

Uttar Pradesh Gramin Bank

Password Policy: Security Standard & Guideline Document (Version 1.0)

Document Information

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Password Policy: Security Standard & Guideline Document (Version 1.0)
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Table of Contents

Sr. No.	Particular	Page No.
01.	Policy Statement, Purpose & Scope of the Policy	04
02.	Definition	05
03.	Key Parameter of Password	05-07
04.	Standards & Guidelines	07
05.	Password Management	08-09
06.	Roles & Responsibilities , Impact	09
07.	Standards Addressed	10
08.	Password Composition and Standard for Finacle-10	10-12
09.	Password Composition and Standard for IAS web portal for biometric Authentication	12
10.	Password Composition and Standard for In-House Developed portals viz. Agrim Portal, Online Leads, Statutory Audit Portal & Deaf Portal, Staff Reimbursement Portal, Intranet Access through website login, Unnayan : e-Learning Portal, OTS Portal, Online Complaints Portal, Intranet Access through website login	13
11.	Password Composition and Standard for Internet Banking	13
12.	Password Composition and Standard for Mobile Banking	13
13.	Password Composition and Standard for portals of other institutions viz. RBI,NABARD,UIDAI,PFMS,NPCI and Others	13
14.	SOP for Password Reset/Unlock/Modification related to user	14-16
15.	Record Maintenance, Suggestions for choosing passwords	16-17
16.	Compliance & Review of the Policy	17

Password Policy: Security Standard & Guideline Document (Version 1.0)

Policy Statement:

Strong passwords are the first line of defence in protecting business data, preventing unauthorised access and ensuring confidentiality towards customer information. A strong **Password Policy** is vital to helping organizations protect critical systems and data, ensure business continuity and minimize compliance risk.

Bank shall implement appropriate password controls for selection, usage and recycling of passwords for protecting information assets of the Bank and its customers. Application software in Bank will have to comply with minimum password standards as specified in this document.

Purpose: The purpose of this policy is to establish a standard for creation of strong passwords, the protection of those passwords, and the frequency of change of the passwords.

A password policy is a set of rules and regulations dictating how employees should create and use passwords. Password policy outline requirements such as minimum length, composition and complexity, expiration dates, storage, etc.

Being a business owner, strong password policy, help to protect intrusion into banking system, restrict towards un authorised access and also protect digital assets. Through strong password we can prevent cybercriminals from accessing accounts and systems.

In recent years, there has been a notable shift from traditional passwords towards more secure and user-friendly authentication methods. The emergence of passphrases—longer sequences of words that are easier for users to remember but harder for attackers to crack—has gained popularity. Passphrases offer a balance between security and convenience, making them an effective alternative to complex passwords.

Additionally, password less authentication methods, such as biometrics (fingerprints, facial recognition) and hardware tokens (e.g., security keys), are becoming increasingly common. These methods provide stronger security by eliminating the need for users to remember or manage passwords, reducing the risk of phishing and other password-related attacks.

Scope of the Policy: The policy will cover the password parameters for Banking Software Finacle, Biometric Solutions Portal, Internet Banking Services, Mobile Banking Services.

This document addresses Policies and Standards related to the password security and controls of the Bank's information resources.

This Policy applies to all Bank employees and respective outsourced parties who need access to Bank's information resources. The information resources covered under this

Password Policy: Security Standard & Guideline Document (Version 1.0)

policy include system and application software, servers and desktops, and networking/security components.

Definition

The encrypted password or password hash – The part of your password that is generated from your actual password and stored on the system that you are authenticating to. When you type your password to log onto your computer, the password is encrypted. The encrypted password is compared against a stored encrypted password. If the two values are the same then you are granted access. It is this encrypted password or password hash that attackers may intercept as it travels across the network or is stored on a computer.

Password cracking – Attempting to break the encrypted password or password hash.

Brute-force attack – A type of password cracking where every possible character combination is tried until a match is found. Brute-force attacks may be conducted online or offline. Depending on the type of brute-force attack, a direct interface to the authentication infrastructure (for example, Active Directory) or a locally stored copy of the encrypted password or password hash is needed in order to verify if the password guess is correct.

Dictionary attack – A type of password cracking where common words, phrases, and combinations of characters are tried until a match is found.

Password expiration or lifetime – The maximum amount of time between password changes.

Password complexity – The structure of the characters that are required to form a password. These typically consist of a required combination of alphabetic lowercase, alphabetic uppercase, numeric, and special characters. Other rules, such as prohibiting words commonly found in dictionaries, also contribute to password complexity.

Minimum password length – The number of characters that are required to form a password. Combined with password complexity and password expiration or lifetime, password length plays a large part in determining the strength of a password.

Key Parameters of Password**1. Password Length**

Password length is the most crucial factor in a strong password policy. It is recommended that passwords should be as per the length prescribed for users. Strong password as per defined length is a preventive measure towards cracking of a password and protects from unauthorised access.

Password Policy: Security Standard & Guideline Document (Version 1.0)

A strong password provides the greatest protection against brute force attacks. These attacks happen when a hacker tries to gain access to your account by using technology to try every possible password combination until they find the right one.

2. Password Complexity

Password complexity is the next most important factor in a robust password policy. It refers to combining various types of symbols, numbers, uppercase and lowercase letters, and other special characters to form a single password. Alternatively, passphrases that combine 4-5 randomly chosen words are also a good password strategy.

3. Password Expiration

Passwords/PINs needed to be changed regularly with in stipulated timeframe as prescribed.

4. Multi-Factor Authentication

Multi-factor authentication (MFA) is a critical security measure that requires more than one method of authentication from independent categories of credentials to verify a user's identity. For example, in addition to a password, a user must provide another form of authentication to access an account, such as a fingerprint or a one-time code sent to a different device.

MFA adds an extra layer of security to help to prevent unauthorized access to accounts and systems. It also makes it more difficult for attackers to compromise accounts, as they would need to obtain multiple forms of authentication to gain access. In addition, MFA can help to reduce the risk of account takeover and other types of cyber-attacks and provides peace of mind for users, knowing that their accounts are better protected.

5. Password History

A password history policy determines the number of unique new passwords that must be associated with a user account before the user can reuse old passwords. Password reuse is a common problem as most users find it easier to reuse passwords for a long time rather than create a new one. Unfortunately, the longer the same password is used for a particular account, the greater the chance that an attacker will be able to determine the password through brute-force attacks. If users are required to change their password but reuse an old password, the effectiveness of a good password policy is significantly reduced.

6. Password Reuse

While creating and managing multiple passwords, reuse of passwords must be avoided. The risks of password reuse are higher as, it's easy for any unauthorised user to check and see if any of the passwords they've recently acquired may match with user credential.

7. Password Sharing

As password is a key element for access into system, through unauthorised access/login any unauthorised person can do anything up to permissible extent of user/customer's power/limits. Password sharing makes personal and professional data vulnerable to cybersecurity threats and must be avoided at all times.

8. Failed Login Attempts

Failed login attempts may result from employees forgetting their login credentials or hackers attempting to access a user's account. Therefore, monitoring and managing failed login attempts is of the utmost importance, as they can lead to privacy and personal data breaches.

A temporary account/login lockout (with certain time frame) after fix consecutive failed attempts or time-doubling throttling (in defined minutes) between each retry (0, 1, 2, 4, 8, etc.) will be set in the system. A permanent account lockout occurs after defined consecutive failed attempts and re-registration/reset activity will be done as per the services.

9. Password Screening

The replication of credentials significantly heightens the risk of unauthorized access to user which may lead potentially exposing sensitive information as well as unauthorised login. In cases where a user enters an incorrect password, the system should provide a clear message prompting them to choose a different one while explaining why their initial choice was rejected.

Standards and Guidelines:

Confidentiality of passwords

- Passwords should remain confidential and not be shared, posted or otherwise divulged in any manner.
- All access codes including user ID passwords, network passwords, PINs etc. shall not be shared with anyone, including colleagues, personal assistants and family members. These should be treated as sensitive, confidential information.
- Passwords should not be revealed to the controlling officer or any co-worker even while on vacation.
- Users shall be responsible for all activity performed with their user IDs. Users shall not permit others to perform any activity with their user IDs or perform any activity with IDs belonging to other users.
- Passwords must not be communicated through e-mail messages or other forms of electronic communication.
- Passwords shall not be revealed on questionnaires or security forms.

Password Policy: Security Standard & Guideline Document (Version 1.0)

- No password shall be traveling in clear text; the hashed form of the password should be used. To get around the possibility of replay of the hashed password, it shall be used along with a randomization parameter.
- The backend database shall store hash of the individual passwords and never passwords in readable form.

Password Management

- Bank will follow the password composition guidelines mentioned in the policy. If systems do not support these settings an exception must be filed to that effect.
- All user/customer-level passwords associated with Banking Software Finacle, Biometric Solutions Portal, Internet Banking Services, Mobile Banking Services shall be changed periodically as per mentioned norms. Users shall not be able to reuse previous passwords up to defined time frame.
- Password shall be enforced to be of a minimum length and comprising of mix of alphabets, numbers and characters.
- Passwords shall not be stored in readable form in batch files, automatic logon scripts, Internet browsers or related data communication software, in computers without access control, or in any other location where unauthorized persons might discover or use them.
- All PINs (Personal Identification Numbers) shall be constructed with the defined rules.
- The "Remember Password" feature of applications shall not be used.
- On first time login or in case of password reset into systems/services applications with administrator created passwords, should force changing of password by the user.
- The password shall be changed immediately if the password is suspected of being disclosed, or known to have been disclosed to an unauthorized party.
- Password shall be enforced to be of a minimum length and comprising of mix of alphabets, numbers and characters.
- Users shall be required to change their passwords periodically and not be able to reuse previous passwords.
- For Password Change Control, both the old and new passwords are required to be given whenever a password change is required.
- There shall be a system to ensure that users should be notified to change their password.
- The user-ID and password should be authenticated as a whole. Authentication failure should provide an error message to the user that indicates an incorrect login. The error message must not indicate whether the user ID is right or wrong. (e.g. "incorrect login" or "incorrect password").
- Files containing passwords should be encrypted.
- Passwords should be entered in non-display fields.

Password Policy: Security Standard & Guideline Document (Version 1.0)
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- The software should enforce a password change following the initial logon.
- Vendor Supplied User-IDs/Passwords, encryption keys, and other access codes included with vendor-supplied systems should be promptly changed. Default passwords shipped with software, networking components should be changed.

Roles and Responsibilities:

Role	Responsibilities
System Administrators	System Administrators will change the password configurations of systems under their supervision to comply with the document. Users will have to comply with the requirements of password security and control policy.
Account Administrators	Ensure that operating system and / or application controls are in place to enforce password rules. Ensure that system service accounts are configured with strong and preferably random passwords. Set initial passwords to random sequences, and require that the password be changed on the user's first login.
UPM User	Ensure the reset of any user must be done on behalf of the approval of competent authority as mentioned in SOP.
End users	Use passwords that comply with the password criteria. Advise the Business Unit Head if they suspect their password has been compromised, and promptly changes it. Do not write down passwords. Never disclose the password to anyone.
Customer	Ensure the confidentiality of password/PINs

Impact

THREAT	IMPACT	LIKELIHOOD
Misuse of the system due to password sharing	High	High
Compromise of passwords due to weak passwords	High	High
Compromise of passwords because of frequent recycling of passwords	Medium	Medium
Compromise of user data due to non-activation of screen saver password	High	Low

Password Policy: Security Standard & Guideline Document (Version 1.0)

Standards Addressed

ISO 27001:2013 Control (s)

- A.9.2.4 – Management of secret authentication information of users.
- A.9.3.1 – Use of secret authentication information.
- A.9.4.3 – Password Management system.

PCI-DSS Control (s)

- Requirement #: Do not use vendor-supplied defaults for system passwords and other security parameters.
- Requirement #: Verify user identity before performing password resets.
- Requirement #: If a session has been idle for more than 15 minutes, require the user to re- authenticate to re-activate the terminal or session.
- Requirement #: Require a minimum password length of at least -7- characters.
- Requirement #: Limit repeated access attempts by locking user ID.
- Requirement #: Set the lockout duration to a minimum of 30 minutes.

Password Composition and Standard for Fiancle-10

- Passwords should have minimum length of (8) eight characters.
- Passwords should have maximum length of (16) sixteen characters.
- Password should be consisting of alphabets, numbers and special characters.
- All passwords ***must include at least three of the following four characteristics*** and use the combination best suited according to the specific environment and known vulnerabilities:
 - At least one lower case character (a, b, c)
 - At least one upper case character (A, B, C)
 - At least one numeric character (0, 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9)
 - At least one special character (/ , [, - , = , + , ! , # , \$, @ , etc.)
- Pass phrases composed of multiple words are acceptable so long as the three of four complexity rule is applied.
- There will be a dual factor authentication for login i.e. Password along with Biometric Authentication.

Password Age

- This new password should not be any of the previous 20 passwords.
- This new password can be changed only after 0 days.
- This new password will expire after 60 days.

Password Policy: Security Standard & Guideline Document (Version 1.0)

Account lockout

- 3 attempts are allowed before the account is locked out.

Disabling of User' IDs

- Critical applications should have a provision for the system administrators to be able to temporarily disable / re-enable User-IDs in case of business or compliance requirements.
- Repeated Unsuccessful login attempts should lock the user for a minimum of 30 minutes or until assigned administrator enables the user id.
- User IDs of employees who are under suspension, sabbatical leave and availing leave beyond 30 days should be disabled on immediate basis.
- Re-enabling of User IDs should be performed after approval from appropriate authority.
- User IDs of superannuated/terminated employees should be disabled permanently.

One Time Use of Initial Passwords

- A user must be provided with an initial password by the administrator. The users must change this password during the first logon into the system (One-time password).

Reset of the password

- Password should be reset as per under mentioned SOP mention in the policy.

User Capability to Select Passwords

- Users should be provided with the capability to change their password on the login interface (after authentication).

Successful login message

- The banks information processing system should display a standard login message that "Unauthorized use of the Bank applications is prohibited" after logging in or at the time of unsuccessful access attempts. Lack of a warning against misuse of the systems, may be legally understood as an oversight on the part of the bank in defending against misuse of systems.

Procedure for Password Reset

- User must make the request in the UCMR form.
- BH/RH/HOD-HO (competent authority) upon his agreement signs and forward the form to concerned Regional Office/Head Office.
- Designated officers at identified offices will verify the form and upon his agreement, will reset the password by ensuring maker-checker mechanism.
- The designated officer reset the password to predetermined value and records the

Password Policy: Security Standard & Guideline Document (Version 1.0)

reset on the form and inform to users (whom ID has been reset) accordingly.

- Concerned user will login with informed password (after reset) and system will insist to make new password.

Password Composition and Standard for IAS web portal for Biometric Authentication

- Passwords should have minimum length of (8) eight characters.
- Passwords should have maximum length of (16) sixteen characters.
- Password should be consisting of alphabets, numbers and special characters.
 - All passwords **must include the following characteristics** At least one lower case character (a, b, c)
 - At least one upper case character (A, B, C)
 - At least one numeric character (0, 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9)
 - At least one special character (/, [, -, =, +, !, #, \$, @, etc.)

Password Composition and Standard for In-House Developed portals viz. Agrim Portal, Online Leads, Statutory Audit Portal & Deaf Portal, Staff Reimbursement Portal, Intranet Access through website login, Unnayan : e-Learning Portal, OTS Portal, Online Complaints Portal, Intranet Access through website login

- Passwords should have minimum length of (8) eight characters.
- Passwords should have maximum length of (16) sixteen characters.
- Password should be consisting of alphabets, numbers and special characters.
- All passwords **must include at least three of the following four characteristics** and use the combination best suited according to the specific environment and known vulnerabilities:
 - At least one lower case character (a, b, c)
 - At least one upper case character (A, B, C)
 - At least one numeric character (0, 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9)
 - At least one special character (/, [, -, =, +, !, #, \$, @, etc.)

Password Age

- This new password should not be any of the previous 3 passwords.
- This new password can be changed only after 0 days.
- This new password will expire after 60 days.

Disabling of User' IDs

- User IDs of employees who are under suspension, sabbatical leave and availing leave beyond 30 days should be disabled on immediate basis.

Password Policy: Security Standard & Guideline Document (Version 1.0)

- Re-enabling of User IDs should be performed after approval from appropriate authority.
- User IDs of superannuated/terminated employees should be disabled permanently.

Password Composition and Standard for Internet Banking

- The password cannot consist of all the characters as are in your Username. For e.g. If your Username is "Bob", then your password cannot be "Bobby".
- Passwords should have minimum length of (8) eight characters.
- Passwords should have maximum length of (16) sixteen characters.
- Password should mandatorily contain digits, letters and special character
- All passwords must include at least three of the four following characteristics:
 - At least one numeric character (0, 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9)
 - At least one special character. That are either of \$#^@\%.
 - At least one lower case character (a, b, c)
 - At least one upper case character (A, B, C)
- Spaces are not allowed in between Password.
- Password cannot be the same as any of your previous five password(s)
- Sign on password recreation will be allowed online for customers under 2FA. Password can be generated by user himself/ herself using Email ID and OTP.
- Virtual Key board for entering sign on password and transaction password will be provided for customers of Internet Banking.
- There will be an expiry period set for passwords provided to customers and application administrators. Any change in password expiry period will be effected with the approval from ORMC.

Password Composition and Standard for Mobile Banking

- There will be two type of PIN 'Login Pin' & 'Transaction Pin'.
- Length of Login Pin will be of 4 digits (Numeric).
- Length of Transaction Pin will be of 4 digits (Numeric)
- Login Pin will expire in 90 days.
- Transaction Pin will expire in 90 days.

Password Composition and Standard for portals of other institutions viz. RBI,NABARD,UIDAI,PFMS,NPCI and Others

- Composition of password standard will be followed as per the fixed guidelines of the concerned institutions/agencies.

❖ **SOP for Password Reset/Unlock/Modification related to user**

➤ **For Finacle Login**

- All users will initiate their written request with their full signature on annexed UCMR form with their complete detail viz. user ID, Sol ID, required changes, EC No., Mobile Number, Full Name, DOB, status of biometric enable/disable, reason for requested change etc.
- Branch Manager/Sr.Manager-HRM or above at Regional Offices/HODs at Head Office, will recommend the request of employee on the same UCMR on behalf of genuineness of the request.
- If Branch Manager's ID has to be reset/modified, he/she initiate their request through UCMR directly to their Regional Office for recommendation & doing the needful. In receipt of such request Sr.Manager-HRM or above at Regional Offices/HODs at Head Office, will recommend the request of employee on the same UCMR on behalf of genuineness of the request.
- On the basis of duly recommended UCMR form, designated officer as maker & checker at ROs/HOs will do the needful changes in the system. As UPM user is restricted for various menu option in Finacle and relates to HR, Hence, while identifying the maker-checker, official who is looking into HR matters should be designated. At RO & HO level alternate official should also be assigned as maker & checker in view of business continuity plan in case of non-availability of designated officials.
- While doing any changes related to password d, maker-checker should make sure the due diligence viz. status of authorised biometric disable, place of posting of staff at requested branch etc.
- After needful changes, designated official will convey about changes/default password, directly to the requested employee over their mentioned mobile number ensuring due diligence.
- Password should not be conveyed through emails and in any written form.
- After password reset user should login into system and system should ask to users for creation of new password at very first stage.

➤ **For IAS web portal for Biometric Enable/Disable**

- All users will initiate their written request with their full signature on annexed UCMR form with their complete detail viz. user ID, Sol ID, required changes, EC No., Mobile Number, Full Name, DOB, status of biometric enable/disable, reason for requested change etc.
- Branch Manager/Sr.Manager-HRM or above at Regional Offices/HODs at Head Office, will recommend the request of employee on the same UCMR on behalf of genuineness of the request.

Password Policy: Security Standard & Guideline Document (Version 1.0)
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- If Branch Manager's biometric option has to be modified, he/she initiate their request through UCMR directly to their Regional Office for recommendation & doing the needful. In receipt of such request Sr.Manager-HRM or above at Regional Offices/HODs at Head Office, will recommend the request of employee on the same UCMR on behalf of genuineness of the request. While recommending for biometric disable only a valid reason should be there. In case of temporary reason, biometric disable approval should be for definite time line.
 - On the basis of duly recommended UCMR form, designated officer as maker & checker at ROs/HOs will do the needful changes in the system. As UPM user is associated with user modification power option in Finacle and relates to HR, Hence, while identifying the maker-checker for biometric portal, official who is looking into HR matters should be designated. At RO & HO level alternate official should also be assigned as maker & checker in view of business continuity plan in case of non-availability of designated officials.
 - While doing any changes related to biometric enablement/disablement, maker-checker should make sure the due diligence.
 - After needful changes, designated official will convey about changes/default password, directly to the requested employee over their mentioned mobile number ensuring due diligence.
- **For In-House Developed portals viz. Agrim Portal, Online Leads, Statutory Audit Portal, Deaf Portal, Staff Reimbursement Portal, Unnayan: e-Learning Portal, OTS Portal, Online Complaints Portal, Intranet Access through website login & other**
- Written request in form of UCMR will be raised by the assigned user (of the portal) for reset the password associated with these portals.
 - After proper recommendation through Branch/RO, the nodal officers of related department of RO/HO will reset the password as per given access as admin user of the portals.

List of portals with department details

Sr. No.	Portal Name	Owner Department
1.	Agrim Portal	Credit
2.	Online Leads	Credit
3.	Statutory Audit Portal	Operations
4.	Deaf Portal	Operations
5.	Staff Reimbursement Portal	HRM
6.	Unnayan: e-Learning Portal	HRM
7.	OTS Portal	Recovery
8.	Online Complaints Portal	Legal

Password Policy: Security Standard & Guideline Document (Version 1.0)

9.	Intranet Access through website login	IT
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- After needful changes, designated official will convey about changes/default password, directly to the requested employee over their mentioned mobile number.

➤ **For Mobile Banking**

- In case of requirement of reset of PIN for mobile banking services, user will have to give written request at their home branch.
- Alternate option for reset the PIN will be explored to ease the user with additional factor of authentication.

➤ **For Internet Banking**

- In case of the requirement of password reset/unlock user, Internet Banking user will have the self-operating option to reset their password/unlock through internet banking URL by on the basis of OTP on their registered Mobile Number.

➤ **For portals of other institutions viz. RBI, NABARD, UIDAI, PFMS, NPCI and Others**

- Password will be reset on the basis of stipulated guidelines of the concerned institutions/agencies.

Record Maintenance:

- All UCMR forms must be preserved at the respective end along with an indexing in a register.

Suggestions for choosing passwords: Passwords may be chosen such that they are difficult-to-guess yet easy-to-remember. Methods such as the following may be employed

- String together several words to form a pass-phrase as a password.
- Transform a regular word according to a specific method e.g. making every other letter a number reflecting its position in the word.
- Combine punctuation and/or numbers with a regular word.
- Create acronyms from words in a song, a poem, or any other known sequence of words.
- Bump characters in a word a certain number of letters up or down the alphabet.
- The password shall not be a word found in a dictionary (English or foreign).
- The password shall not be a common usage word such as names of family, pets, friends, co-workers, fantasy characters, etc.
- The password shall not be based on computer terms and names, commands, sites, companies, hardware, software.

Password Policy: Security Standard & Guideline Document (Version 1.0)

- The password shall not be based on birthdays and other personal information such as addresses and phone numbers.
- The password shall not be a word or number pattern like aaabbb, qwerty, zyxxvuts, 123321, etc. or any of the above spelled backwards.

Compliance:

Personnel authorized as Internal Auditor shall periodically review the adequacy of such controls and their compliance.

Personnel authorized as IS Audit/Application Audit shall check respective applications for password complexity and password policy incorporation.

Review of the policy:

This policy shall be reviewed on annual basis i.e. one year from the date of approval by the Hon'ble Board or till the next approval whichever is earlier.

Any fresh/additional guidelines issued by RBI/NABARD/Sponsor Bank or any such statutory/regulatory/supervisory etc. body shall supersede this policy with concurrence of the Chairman subject to reporting/informing the Hon'ble Board.

The validity of the policy shall be three years from the date of approval of the Board. In case the policy cannot be reviewed on or before due date, The Chairman is authorized for allowing to continue with the policy for three months for the due date of review.

End of the document